



# SHOOT TO THRILL

FSDL

Two **stoppage-time goals** sealed the outcomes in the ISL semifinals, setting up a final clash between Mohun Bagan and Bengaluru FC.

**L**alengmawia Ralte (Apuia) produced a stunning finish late in added time to find that elusive goal which had kept a gathering of over 50,000 Mohun Bagan Super Giant fans waiting for their moment of triumph.

Apuia (**above, 45**) justified his billing as one of the most accomplished (and expensive) Indian midfielders as he pulled off a spectacular long-ranger past Albino Gomes in the Jamshedpur FC goal.

This effort realised the 2-0 margin that helped Mohun Bagan ensure a decisive 3-2 lead on aggregate and secured its place in the Indian Super League final for the third time in succession.

Apuia's individual brilliance proved the perfect piece in the final denouement of the ISL semifinal's second leg, where Mohun Bagan succeeded in overturning the

ultra-defensive strategy of Jamshedpur FC. The Red Miners arrived with the advantage of leading the first leg 2-1 and sought to create a fortress around their goal by placing the bulk of their players in a low-block defensive role.

After a lacklustre first half, Mohun Bagan went ahead in the 51st minute when its Australian forward Jason Cummings converted a penalty to create the first breach in the seemingly impregnable defence planned by Jamshedpur FC head coach Khalid Jamil.

The match did not see the level of contest expected in a semifinal as Jamshedpur devoted itself to defending in an effort to preserve the one-goal lead.

The lopsided nature of the contest was evident in the way Mohun Bagan enjoyed nearly 75 per cent possession but found all its

efforts falling flat in the jungle of legs stationed in the Jamshedpur box.

The first half justifiably remained barren as Jamshedpur put up a resolute defence, frustrating Mohun Bagan's every effort to take the lead. Jamshedpur mounted some counter-attacks but lacked the incisiveness to upset Mohun Bagan's defensive arrangement.

With the duo of Tom Aldred and Alberto Rodriguez holding fort in the Mohun Bagan backline, Jamshedpur's plan of surprising the opponent with pacy counter-attacks did not bear fruit.

Mohun Bagan head coach Jose Molina persevered with his starting line-up and did not seek any alteration in the team's attack after the break.

His faith in the combination of Australian forwards, Jamie Maclaren and Cummings, at the centre of the